Alexis “AJ” Jackson

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EDUCATION

2021–Present | **Ph.D., Environmental Engineering Sciences** | University of Florida, Gainesville, FL. Dissertation: “Connecting Hydrologic Patterns and Vegetation Composition to Wetland Carbon Storage Across Spatial and Temporal Scales.” Advisor: Dr. David Kaplan. Successfully defended October 2026; degree expected December 2026.

May 2020 | **B.S., Biological Sciences** | Virginia Polytechnic Institute and State University (Virginia Tech), Blacksburg, VA.

RESEARCH & PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

2021–Present | **Doctoral Researcher, University of Florida** | Investigate how hydrology, vegetation, and environmental conditions affect wetland soil organic carbon across national, watershed, and process scales. Integrate National Wetland Condition Assessment data, field sampling, GIS, statistical testing, and hydrologic modeling; present findings to scientific and public audiences.

Jan 2022–October 2026 | **Laboratory Manager, Phelps Lab, University of Florida** | Coordinate laboratory operations, equipment, training, and safety; facilitate equipment and tool sharing with other laboratories; mentor and support undergraduate researchers; and organize field and laboratory workflows.

May–October 2021 | **Florida Crew Leader, U.S. EPA National Wetland Condition Assessment (EPA NWCA)** | Led field assessments at more than 50 wetland sites in Florida, coordinating collection of soil, water, vegetation, and ecological data and working as part of a national wetland monitoring effort.

January–April 2021 | **Research Intern, Archbold Biological Station** | Conducted independent research on aboveground plant biomass across elevation gradients in Florida scrub; studied endemic plant communities and participated in prescribed-fire management activities.

May 2019–May 2020 | **NSF Research Experiences for Undergraduates (REU) Fellow, Hotchkiss Lab, Virginia Tech** | Studied the effects of temperature and water level on wetland carbon cycling and collaborated on an NSF-supported stream-ecology project.

LEADERSHIP, ORGANIZING & ADVOCACY

2024–Present | **Student Section Chair (previous Education chair), Society of Wetland Scientists** | Helped organize student virtual conferences across two years. Co-led the July 31–August 1, 2026, program with approximately 35–40 registrants and four to six speakers; developed the agenda, coordinated speakers, helped build the Gather Town venue, and managed virtual-event logistics.

2024–2026 | **Ambassador, University of Florida Water Institute** | Co-organized student showcase events for student research, networking, and professional development. Co-developed Student Hydro Highlights, interviewing researchers, writing articles, and adapting stories for social media.

Undergraduate years | **Event Coordinator / Chair, Virginia Tech NAACP** | Organized campus programming and advocated with university leadership on responses to hate speech, student protections, and Title IX-related concerns.

Undergraduate years | **Vice President, Minorities in Agriculture, Natural Resources and Related Sciences (MANRRS), Virginia Tech** | Supported student programming, professional development, conference engagement, and peer connections.

Undergraduate years | **Secretary, Student African American Sisterhood, Virginia Tech** | Coordinated student-organization activities, communications, and campus programming.

Undergraduate years | **ACC Student Leadership / Food-Insecurity Initiative, Virginia Tech** | Participated in a year-long cross-campus leadership effort focused on food insecurity and development of a campus food-bank initiative.

SCIENCE COMMUNICATION, EDUCATION & PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT

2025 | **Scientist in Every Florida School — “Wading in the Wetlands with AJ”** | Led a virtual wetland-science session for 75 K–5 students in Gilchrist, Charlotte, and Martin counties (September 18), and additional in-person school outreach in Ocala (November 13).

April 15, 2025 | **Panelist**, “Is Florida’s Freshwater Safe?” — **Freshwater Fest, Rollins College** | Discussed freshwater science, water quality, and water issues across Florida with community audiences during a public panel

2024–2025 | **Precollegiate Education and Training (CPET), University of Florida** | Designed and delivered interactive research and data-analysis workshops for high-school students and educators, introducing scientific questions, environmental data, and research skills.

2025 | **Coastal and Estuarine Research Federation Legacy Fund Scholarship Committee** | Reviewed scholarship applications and participated in selection of two awardees with faculty committee members.

July 2025 | **Archbold Summer Camp — Virtual Invited Speaker** | Presented an accessible, field-connected wetland ecology lesson for young learners.

February 2024 | **Black in Natural History Museums — Ecology Station Lead** | Designed and staffed an interactive ecology station for the public at the Florida Museum of Natural History.

2022 | **RamosStrong Motivational Group Mentor** | Provided academic guidance and support to students in Gainesville.

2020 | **Boys & Girls Clubs — Youth Development Staff** | Planned and supervised youth programming in education, STEM, arts, health, and leadership.

ACADEMIC PRESENTATIONS

June 2026 | Jackson, A. “Connecting Hydrologic Patterns and Vegetation Composition to Wetland Carbon Storage Across Spatial and Temporal Scales.” Society of Wetland Scientists Annual Meeting, New Orleans, LA. Oral presentation.

May 2025 | Jackson, A., Kaplan, D., and Reiss, K. “Drivers of Wetland Carbon Storage Across the United States.” American Ecological Engineering Society, Athens, GA. Oral presentation.

June 2024 | Jackson, A., Cohen, M., and Kaplan, D. “Connecting Hydrology and Soil Organic Carbon Storage in Southeastern US Flatwoods Wetlands.” SWS South Atlantic Chapter Conference, Pensacola Beach, FL. Oral presentation.

April 2024 | Jackson, A., and Chin, N. “Machine Learning in Wetland Ecology.” SWS Student Virtual Conference. Oral presentation.

April 2024 | Jackson, A. “DEI in Wetland Science.” SWS Student Virtual Conference. Oral presentation.

November 2023 | Jackson, A., Reiss, K., and Kaplan, D. “Drivers of Wetland Soil Carbon Across the United States.” Society for Freshwater Science Southeast Chapter Meeting, Columbus, GA. Oral presentation.

July 2022 | Jackson, A. “BIMS Bites: Wetlands.” Black in Marine Science. Public-facing presentation.

May 2022 | Jackson, A., Kaplan, D., and Reiss, K. “Linking Patterns of Wetland Soil Carbon and Non-Native Plant Richness Across the United States.” Joint Aquatic Sciences Meeting. Poster.

May 2021 | Jackson, A., and Menges, E. “Aboveground Biomass Variation Along Elevation Gradients in Florida Scrub.” Florida Native Plant Society Conference. Oral presentation.

December 2020 | Jackson, A., Bretz, K., and Hotchkiss, E. “Sinks and Sources: The Dynamic Contributions of Riparian Wetlands to Catchment Carbon Budgets.” American Geophysical Union Fall Meeting. Poster.

PUBLICATIONS

Jackson, A., Reiss, K. C., Chin, N., & Kaplan, D. (2026). Patterns and drivers of wetland soil carbon across the United States. Manuscript under review (Ecological Indicators); preprint available on SSRN: https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.7498816

Bretz, K. A., Jackson, A. R., Rahman, S., Monroe, J. M., & Hotchkiss, E. R. (2021). Integrating ecosystem patch contributions to stream corridor carbon dioxide and methane fluxes. Journal of Geophysical Research: Biogeosciences, 126, e2021JG006313. https://doi.org/10.1029/2021JG006313

AWARDS & RECOGNITION

2025 | Sally and William Glick Graduate Research Endowment, University of Florida

2024 & 2025 | University of Florida Water Institute Ambassador Award

2023 | University of Florida Water Institute Research Award

2022 | Society of Wetland Scientists Multicultural Mentoring Program (SWaMMP) Awardee

2021 | National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship (NSF GRFP)

2020 | Undergraduate Research Excellence Award, Virginia Tech Office of Undergraduate Research

2020 | Global Change Center Grant Awardee

2019 & 2020 | Society for Freshwater Science INSTARS Fellowship

SKILLS & ABILITIES

Science communication and public speaking; stakeholder engagement; researcher interviews; science and grant writing; educational programming; virtual and in-person event coordination; speaker recruitment; project management; interdisciplinary collaboration; social media; Zoom and Gather Town; Canva, Adobe Illustrator, Microsoft Office; ArcGIS, GIS, Google Earth Engine, R, Python, and MATLAB.